

# On Ideals and Values

## *Two Models of Positive Activism*

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### A.

It has always been hard to be an idealist.

The idealist is not afraid of difficulties; it is difficulties that create, for him, the tension, the great challenge, the sense of the weight of the burden he must carry; in a certain sense, they are what help him, more than anything, to feel that he is doing something meaningful, that he is indeed stepping outside the circle of egoism and narrow horizons and acting for the repair and transformation of the world. His standing firm against difficulty proves to him his own uprightness, the innocence of his path, the fact that he is doing the good thing, that he is not surrendering to his own personal whims and comfortable habits, that he acts from the correct and fitting motive. The idealist takes all the sweat of his brow, all the toil, the labor and the strength he has invested in efforts to change the face of reality and to repair within it various important and urgent matters, and offers them up as a sacrifice before God; these are his guarantors of a life filled with meaning and purpose. And indeed, when all is said and done, difficulty is, by definition, unpleasant, but the idealist's spirit and resolve stand firm against yielding to it.

The youth movements<sup>[1]</sup> were meant to educate the youth to be idealists, people who devote the bulk of their lives and energy to repair and improvement, to various social and political struggles bearing on national and global reality; people who do not compromise on a bourgeois, comfortable life, but are willing to give their souls for the goals they have set, for the sake of the collective. Out of the creation of large groups of people imbued with idealistic fervor, possessing a shared vision and agreed-upon ideals, social change becomes possible and becomes reality. So it was with Zionism; with communism; with socialism; with environmentalism; and, to make a stark distinction, with Nazism and fascism. And indeed, in a considerable portion of these social movements, youth movements took on highly significant weight.

We find, in recent times (for quite a while now, in fact), a weakening of all the youth movements. This is always explained, rightly, in the context of the postmodern mindset pervading society; and to it are also attached labels of materialism, individualism, emptiness, and so on. And indeed, there is truly a connection among all these things, even if, in the end, the whole argument usually gets mixed together into a comprehensive despair and a general grumbling about the state of the generation, hanging everything on some postmodern demon, as though this itself constituted an explanation.

We, in Bnei Akiva[2] in particular and in Religious Zionism in general, feel like remnants whom God calls[3] to fight the war of the commandment against the general darkness enveloping the Western world, including Israeli society — a darkness that brings with it results far more severe than the decision of many children and teenagers not to join the youth movements. Whether we call it by various names or not, whether we lump it all together under "the Western worldview" or "the postmodern mindset" or not, the feeling remains that the spiritual drift of the times leads in a direction opposite to where we strive and where we struggle to go. We struggle by means of our education, by means of raising counselees imbued with the same spirit in which we ourselves were raised, by means of passing the burning torch from hand to hand, instilling the vision and searing the ideals we deeply believe in into the hearts of our children and youth, so that they will continue our struggle against darkness and impurity, against emptiness and ignorance, against skepticism and self-centeredness, and will continue, and add to, and strengthen our striving and our efforts to illuminate the world (or, at the very least, the Land and the state) with the kingdom of God, with justice, with love, with innocence, with mercy, with valor, with truth, with modesty, with uprightness and with holiness.

But there are times when we feel a loss from within, and it is even more painful. I am not speaking here (nor, in general, in this essay) of religious dropout, whose dimensions — from the point of view at which I stand — are not so significant, and therefore do not disturb our rest so much. I approach the matter more from the point of view of the youth movement. I am speaking of the painful phenomenon, whose dimensions are very great indeed, of abandoning "the movement's way," if one may put it so. We find that many counselees, once they have left the branch framework and crossed over into independent adult life, feel no identification — let alone commitment — to the values and ideals their counselors tried to instill in them, even though they themselves tried to educate their own counselees in that same light. The energetic idealistic culture of the branch — the life full of enthusiasm and energy, the volunteering and the settlement cores, the dreams and the activist fervor — not only fades quickly from memory as the years of adolescence advance, but is often even recalled and perceived as irrelevant, as childish and unsober, as adolescent and immature, as unfitting for real adult life. And it is not that they are not religious enough, and often there is even great educational success on the religious plane; but on the idealistic plane, on the plane of a consciousness of mission and a readiness to devote oneself to actualization and vision, we feel that something is being lost, that this is not where they were meant to arrive, in the branch, in the movement.

A sign of this can be found in a very popular skit which, it seems to me, few graduates of the branches and seminars have not heard, or something like it. The story tells of a group of people in their thirties, usually graduates of some youth-movement branch, who gather together for some "class reunion." At this gathering, one of them takes out a sealed pack, full of scribbled notes. They remember: before the group broke up and each went their own way into their personal life frameworks, at the end of twelfth grade, they sat and proposed that each write on his note where he wants to be in about fifteen years, sealed the notes in the pack, and set a date to open it. From here the story branches according to the narrator's

inspiration, but, in essence, they find that it is precisely the assertive, idealistic fellow, who had declared that he wanted to devote his life to a life of modesty and mission, to a military, educational, settlement, social and political career, and to any field in which the people of Israel would need him — who sits in his respectable suit, his belly before him, and mumbles in embarrassment that life carried him off to a hi-tech position, and that they were young and naïve, and that the reality of life is more complex, and so on and so forth.

I have no interest in engaging with the message of the story[4], as I do with its tone, with the inner note it transmits, since that note reflects well something that exists deep within the accepted educational approach in the youth movements. The counselee who hears the story is filled with a certain disappointment and contempt toward that former idealist, and these combine into a strong inner wish not to be like him. We come out of such an activity with the feeling that now we are more prepared to cope with erosion and bourgeois settling-down, that we are more aware of the danger lurking for us in adult life, the danger of forgetting and eroding and weakening, the danger of loosening our firm grip on the ideals we believe in today beyond all doubt, of "cutting out," of sinking into self-interest and comfort and abandoning the correct and demanding path toward which we are oriented today. The story sets up a barrier between the world of adults, worn down and swept toward careerism and self-actualization, and us as youth, and between how we want to see the world of adults that we ourselves will build; it highlights the difficulty of imposing our idealistic world upon the reality of normal life, but precisely in this it sets before us the great challenge, on which everything depends, and spurs us to meet it with resolve and to succeed. It takes the fact that the language of the youth movements usually remains with the youth, and the common reality in which enthusiastic, flame-kindling talk of revolutions and fundamental social change is not heard in a post-high-school (or post-army) environment, and reads them in a way that does not allow for self-examination, doubt and renewed thought, but rather, on the contrary, as proof that this is indeed a very difficult way of life to implement and that the evil inclination is great, but that precisely because of this the task is vital and rests, with full responsibility, on us alone.

The trouble is that this story, despite what it arouses in counselees of branch age (mainly the older teens[5]), is actually quite accurate, if we disregard the exaggerated, stereotypical-picturesque description. And indeed, a common phenomenon, at least from my point of view, is precisely the feeling that ultimately leads to the abandonment of "the spirit of the movement," letting life run itself by other compasses. The feeling shared by many, some time after leaving the intensive branch culture, is that one must move on, must mature. And for some reason the Bnei-Akiva-ist mindset comes to seem an immature thing, a thing worthy of mockery, a term of derision[6], a thing that is undesirable and unfit to stand at the center of adult life and direct it, as though — as it were — it were an outdated language, no longer at all capable of describing and containing the renewing reality of life. The foundations of thought and the "articles of faith" of the Bnei-Akiva-ist spirit suddenly stand for criticism and re-judgment, opened to doubts, and slowly collapse, leaving a feeling of a ruined, or at least abandoned, structure.

## B.

Up to this point I have called the abandoned youthful mindset by all sorts of names, and described it in emotional and typological terms, in order to give a general, basic sense of understanding of what the matter is about. In order to advance further, I wish to carry out a more precise analysis of what I will call, from now on, "the idealistic mindset." [7] Alongside the analysis I will also raise difficulties and existential problems that have arisen for me as a result of my education toward idealism, and which I believe reflect wonderings and inner struggles, not always fully conscious, that arise in others coming from a similar background.

Idealistic activity invests immense psychic forces in reality. One could say that the idealist's thought and idea are devoted to three foundational questions — first, what is flawed, distorted or negative in present reality; second, how I want reality to look, what the ideal character is; and third, what are the means, the ways, the methods, the initiatives, by which I succeed in changing reality and bringing it to the status I deem fitting. The solutions the idealist grants to these questions, chief among them the third [8], will decide the essence of his life: the projects to which he will devote his time, the tasks for which he will give his soul, the goals he will set before his eyes wherever he turns. Therefore, from some stage in his maturation, the idealistic person holds firmly and decisively to the conclusions he has reached. He cannot allow himself skepticism and hesitation regarding these subjects, since they are the very breath of his life, and the whole edifice he builds in his life stands on the foundation he determines at the stage of self-formation. To give a parable from the early twentieth century — a young man of eighteen who chose to sever himself from his entire old world in order to immigrate to the Land and contribute his share to the Zionist settlement and agricultural project, and who then changed his mind and his view regarding his attitude toward the Zionist project, and decided that he now adhered to Haredi anti-Zionist approaches — is, by all accounts, truly a pitiable young man. He destroyed, with his own hands, his entire world for a purpose in which, in the end, he himself no longer believes; all the years, all the strength, all the money and all the resources he invested have, from his point of view, gone entirely to waste — they have no positive value at all from his new point of view. Since the psychic price of an ideational transformation is so severe and critical, the idealist will naturally prefer not to open himself to those very possibilities, and to strengthen his soul with a living, burning faith in the specific ideals he has chosen as the map of his life.

A different, similar but distinct, way to explain the idealist's strong grip on his beliefs and positions is the bond that exists between certainty and fervor. The certain psychic place is, seemingly, the only one that enables real self-sacrifice; the more energy I expend for some deed, the more certainty and confidence I need in the rightness and importance of the matter. The idealist cannot allow himself to be tossed between right and wrong, between one opinion and another, between certain and maybe. This is not only because every insight has an immediate, direct practical implication, but also in the opposite direction — the deed forces recognition and reason to be certain of themselves, to stand firm. The moment he recognizes the cracks and gaps in his worldview, the unresolved matters, the problematic,

difficult points in his position — he becomes disconnected from the devoted, enthusiastic psychic mode, at peace with its own deeds, that enables him to go on clinging to his ideals against reality, against difficulty and laziness and comfort.

Part of the foundational idealistic picture of the world is the group, the social collective that carries the shared agenda. The group is basic to the idealistic world for two reasons. The first reason is the possibilities of action — the lone individual is highly limited in his ability to change reality. The group, by contrast, has great power to run meaningful projects, to create noise and awareness, to recruit more supporters and counselees to the shared worldview, and to act for some real change in reality. This is the more technical reason; but the second reason is more essential, psychological. The group constitutes, for the idealistic individual, an existential anchor point; it helps him flee from withdrawing into inner complication and doubt, to retreat from self-entanglement, and to focus on the world of doing, on the world of reality. Even discussions and situation-assessments have a different status when they take place within the "committee" or the "assembly" of the group's members (whether this is a commune, a settlement core, a counseling staff, a party or the like) rather than in a solitary, intimate room; they take place out of a fervor directed from the inside outward, and therefore the discussion, too, will not spill beyond the "tools" of the group, and will not sink into deep skeptical or nihilistic abysses. Let us take, for example, a discussion conducted by a counseling staff at a Bnei Akiva branch regarding whether to compel counselees to participate in prayer. The open, sincere discourse can indeed open up to unexpected places, such as the importance of prayer, but it is highly unlikely to spill over into the question "does God even exist" or into a deep philosophical discussion of the relationship between God's perfection, unmoved from without, and the act of petition in prayer, since this does not belong to this group reality, is not found in its discourse, in its language, in its concern, in the purpose for which it was established.

I wish to stress that when I speak of an opening toward skepticism, I do not mean specifically radical, all-destroying skepticism, the kind that brings a person to a complete dismantling of his grasp of reality and of all the feelings of certainty he holds. This kind of skepticism seems to us, even today, a negative thing from which we should distance ourselves, choosing life instead. The main reason we sometimes find ourselves in inner tension with the idealist's absolute self-certainty is that this certainty touches domains where it is less clear to us how one can be so sure. When a person tells me that he believes with all his heart and soul in the vision of world peace, I tend to believe him and to understand him, to understand how, out of so foundational a faith, he is willing to act with fervor and resolve. The vision itself sounds to us like an inner, unmediated thing, a kind of foundational faith that, if it exists, simply exists, and it is hard, almost impossible, to cast doubt upon it. But, by contrast, the idealist believes not only in some overarching vision, not only in some grand dream or principled call for direction, but also in specific deeds, in means, in ways of acting.

Let me give an example from the period of the struggle against the Disengagement plan: let us say we are certain that the plan is bad and that every possible effort must be made to

prevent it. Now the question arises, how do we do this, what do we have at our disposal to bring about the desired result. Let us say I was asked to be responsible for a national project of distributing orange ribbons; and from that moment I am tasked with running around from place to place, lecturing, explaining, raising donations, transporting the ribbons and distributing them by region, convening and appointing regional coordinators, recruiting volunteers and distributors, organizing, publicizing, telephoning, working, laboring, and so on and so forth. All this effort, all this toil, is made possible from a firm point at which I am certain that this is the right thing to do, and that is why I invest so much in it. But the fact that I am certain of my general opposition to the Disengagement plan does not directly entail my capacity to invest in and devote myself to the orange-ribbons project. This capacity depends on a further factor, namely, the connection between the result and the deed, the relationship between the purpose and the action meant to bring it about. As long as I feel uncertain about the question — does the orange-ribbons project truly help to stop the plan — it is very hard for me to devote myself to it. And this question — whether the project truly helps, or: what are the project's chances of bringing about the desired result — is not a value-based, religious or ideological question. It is a factual question, an empirical, objective one. The tension is between the wish to devote myself to important activity, and the part of me that gnaws and says — who says this is indeed important activity? Why force my reason to say it will help, when, viewed coldly and dryly, viewed from outside, out of estrangement and objectivity and without the enthusiastic, swept-up ideological "touch," I would not necessarily arrive at this conclusion?

Here we touch on another of the characteristics of the idealistic mindset. A further foundational principle constituting idealistic spiritual life is deep trust in the power of the individual to change, to influence, reality. In the youth movement this finds expression in teaching about the youth's ability to bring about revolutions, to effect broad social change. Trust in the broad, real power of deeds is essential in order to enable devotion; it helps narrow the gap yawning between the smallness and locality of the specific deed and the generality and sublimity of the purpose, of the vision, of the spiritual goal underlying those idealistic deeds. Life fills with weighty responsibility and value-based tension only when I believe that what I do changes something, matters, has implications, results. However, at times the piercing, reflective gaze reveals that this basic assumption, too, is not objectively necessary; it is not derived from empirical experience and analytical reason, but, on the contrary, it is an axiom I need — to some degree against simple experience — in order to substantiate a desired way of life, in which my deeds have meaning and in which I do not sink into the nihilism or emptiness of "what difference does it make" and "all is vanity." And thereby, in moments of distress and crisis, it loses its meaning and its power, for if it does not arise from reality, why should it reflect reality? And if it does not reflect reality, then, once again, I find no justification for granting my deeds meaning and importance, and certainly not fateful, universally significant meaning. All the more so if I am to burden myself with projects and undertakings whose entire concern is their broad, distant, "visionary" real-world purpose — for from the moment I stopped believing in the criticality of every tiny deed and began to doubt the real, result-based meaning of each and every one of my deeds, I no longer find the psychic strength for it.

Two further matters occupy a place in the general idealistic mindset — matters essentially intertwined with one another — namely, optimism and utopianism. These two complement trust in the power of the individual, in order to create a full worldview in which there is a tight and direct connection between deeds and the supreme purpose we wish to attain. Utopianism is basic for a realistic description of the unfolding of the results of relatively small deeds into a supreme, complete destiny; perfection is possible, it is attainable, and it will come fully into actuality if only we give our strength and effort to it. If the picture of complete, utopian reality remains a mere dislodged dream, a prophetic vision with no connection to actuality and reality, it will not have the power to move deeds aspiring toward it, striving to advance all the way to it. Beyond this lies the foundational importance of the optimistic approach. Optimism is the fuel of activism; without an optimistic orientation, any existential attempt to overcome laziness and perform actions whose ambition lies several levels beyond the first or second consequence, actions whose intended purpose lies beyond the near, probable results, will fail and sink. Cynicism and pessimism can overtake a person precisely when he seeks to expend great energy, precisely when he must exert himself, labor, withstand difficulty and suffering. Therefore, one who seeks to live a vibrant and dynamic life, full of meaningful occurrence, full of constructive activism, must adopt the optimistic outlook, and only through it read reality. This is, in effect, the root that enables him to pin his hopes on the projects he runs, on the struggles he leads, on the real revolutions he tries to bring about — he strives and believes in their power to change, in their vitality, in their chances of success.

### C.

All these matters we have mentioned so far as characteristics of "idealism" — the strong grip on certainty, the group, trust in the power of the individual, utopianism and optimism — are today undergoing a trend of weakening, or, on another plane, are subject to a philosophical-cultural attack. And indeed, as we noted earlier, this trend, or this attack, is part of what is included under the name "postmodernism." As people raised in the new culture, we too are accustomed to different values, different foundational conceptions, a different language, and we become acquainted with these all the more as we mature, as we go out into the general frameworks of life.

The strong grip on certainty is not grasped by us as a virtue; it no longer appears to us as greatness of spirit, as exceptional understanding, as true self-wholeness — as it perhaps appeared in the modern era[9] — but, on the contrary, we cast doubt on it as well, and search for the artificial mortar that binds together the cracks, the gaps and the unnecessary logical leaps, the psychology of self-persuasion that covers over absolute and merciless intellectual honesty. This casting of doubt is an instinct in a world in which the voices of enthusiastic certainty have fallen silent, the voices of absolutism and the pretension to contain the world's knowledge, to contain the whole truth and the necessary objective good. In our world, the expression of a position is almost always accompanied by some basic reservation, some apology, some leaving of room and humility of mind, some inner recognition that, it turns out, justice is probably not entirely on my side, but that I have no

choice but to present my conclusions. Resoluteness sounds to us today arrogant, false, even alienated. It cannot be that someone with full self-awareness, or intellectual sensitivity, is truly one hundred percent convinced that he, and he alone, holds the truth. After all, he knows there are countless opinions in the world, and he cannot ignore the fact that he is just one more among many, just another narrative among a whole world of narratives, each of which sees itself as the whole of reality exactly as he sees himself and his world as the whole of reality. And if he does indeed ignore this, it is out of self-coercion, out of inner dishonesty. But it is not specifically relativism (the view that truth is relative) and pluralism (the recognition of a multiplicity of opinions) that stand against certainty and struggle with it. The basic mindset blowing through our spiritual world is skepticism. Certainty is built through toil, through effort, through soul-labor. The simple (existential) position is the agnostic one, the one that denies the ability to truly know anything, and if someone wants to be extracted from it, the burden of proof is on him, and he must pave his own way and that of his beliefs against the world, against the ruling culture.

From various directions comes the breakdown of the group and the rise of individualism, the value of the individual in his individuality. It is not my task here to describe the causes and the processes, but the result can be seen in every manifestation of the culture around us — in consumerism, in thought, in politics, in moral discourse, in education, and more. Communism broke down, and so too did our trust in the ability to live within a dense communal framework with others, our will to be existentially dependent on our fellow. Virtual communities, and specific, focused social ties, without an overarching value framework, without any purpose or mission lying outside the territory of natural, everyday existence, are trying to take the place of the group, the settlement core, or the "ideological community." Stepping outside the private circle, breaking out of self-centeredness, seem less self-evident and more difficult, even if the attitude toward them is, in principle, positive. Awareness of the difference between the characters of human beings, of the personal uniqueness of each individual, of the deep difference separating one person from another, has been sharpened considerably, and any talk of a shared human nature — whether in the domain of talents, intuition and reason, primal wills or aesthetic taste — will be received with great suspicion and skeptical criticism.

The general mindset has shifted in a more pessimistic direction. A world that has gone through two world wars, the Holocaust, the failure of the socialist vision, the atomic bomb, cannot hold the same optimism, and these harsh blows have left their mark on the trust we place in history and in humankind. In stark contrast to the futurologists of past eras, who expressed great trust and hope in the intended results of technological development, or in the continuous moral progress of humanity, contemporary pictures of the future are darkened by black prophecies of environmental catastrophe, of growing social alienation, of a technology that conquers humanity, of atomic war, and so forth. Pastoral visions of a repaired world and universal peace are perceived by us as naïve, as concerning some distant end of days that it is not within our power to bring about in the slightest. From this the attitude toward the power of the individual is derived. Our recent history — precisely because it contained many ideologies and utopias that trusted in their ability to improve



and fundamentally transform the world for the better, and these were disappointed — teaches us that it is the nature of reality to slap the faces of idealistic optimists. Various important and immense undertakings collapsed or degenerated, after various people invested in them their lives, their resources, their entire souls, and awareness of this is present in the background of the consciousness of our contemporary.

#### **D.**

In the description in the previous chapter I tried to refrain (relatively) from expressing value judgment, in order first of all to set before us the cultural reality in which we find ourselves, whose influence, and the seeping of whose conceptions into our inner world, into religious society, there is no way to escape. And indeed, various ways of coping have arisen on the philosophical-theological plane and on the ideological plane — some accept, some become estranged, some fight back, some raise partitions, some scorn, some incorporate, some examine cautiously. Every religious conception created against our cultural background constitutes some kind of response, even if it contains no explicit or even conscious relation to the postmodern phenomenon by its name or general essence. I do not wish to address all of these, but to focus on the educational plane alone, and even this only within the scope of our discussion, which is education toward positive, constructive activism.

As stated above, the accepted way of educating toward activism today has not changed essentially from modernist education toward idealism. And indeed, this education runs into the very distress described above, which requires some deeper clarification, a more open and conscious confrontation with the deep claims of the culture before which we stand — whether by way of confrontation and rejection, or by way of partial acceptance of those very claims. I have tried, up to this point, to sketch in general lines those "deep claims," which are not found on a purely philosophical plane but mainly in a kind of experience, in a way of observing reality or in a basic existential approach. The central point I wish to argue is that education today must be careful not to hang the capacity for positive activism on those basic psychic-existential foundations whose relevance, or cultural power, is in significant and undeniable retreat — foundations that, in themselves — if we look and inquire carefully — are not among the foundational principles of the Torah or its necessary beliefs. Indeed, components such as optimism or the power of the individual have become well integrated into our religious-spiritual worldview[10], but we must know not to found our entire educational and faith-based edifice on these components, even if we still hold them to be correct.

#### **E.**

Since above I described how the wish to establish a capacity for positive activism is what drove the idealistic mindset to adopt, with fervor, principles, assumptions and positions that are not necessary in themselves, I must give an answer to the question of how such activism can be grounded without needing those same assumptions. To this end, I wish to

sketch a different kind of idealism, which, for the sake of precision and linguistic distinction, I will not call by the name "idealism," but "value-orientation." But before I proceed to explain what distinguishes activity out of ideals from activity out of values, I must offer a preface.

When we explain our will to do some deed, we can proceed along two paths, two modes of explanation — the causal and the purposive (teleological).[11] Example: my wish to taste a new and pleasant-looking dish can be explained by the words "because I want to know what it tastes like," and can be explained by the words "because I am hungry." The first explanation is purposive, since it sketches a goal, some result that I seek in this deed, and which is therefore the explanation for doing the deed — the deed's purpose. The second explanation, by contrast, is causal, and it is content to describe the psychic force that brings me to this deed, the motive force. While the purposive explanation turns toward reality, toward the outside, and explains the specific will — focused on a particular deed — in light of the aim that is the result of the deed and is the thing truly sought, the causal explanation turns toward the soul, toward the inside, and reveals the natural will that pushed the personality toward the deed.

In the course of normal life, in everyday speech, we make use of both languages as one, without any real distinction. However, although both languages seem, at first glance, natural and true, on more fundamental examination we find that the purposive language contains some falseness, some essential flaw, at least when it stands alone. That is to say: a person who seeks to explain his voluntary deeds only by way of purposive explanation will hit a fundamental logical wall, and this when we keep pulling him further and further with the question "why."

If we take, for example, my wish to write this essay, I can explain it with the reason: "so that people will read it." This is a purposive reason. And if I am asked about the answer I gave, "why do you want people to read your essay?" — I will answer, "so that they will (hopefully) derive some benefit from it." But if they go on to ask me about this answer, "and for what purpose do you want people to derive benefit?" — here I will be forced to answer something like: "because I wish for people to be well." If they continue to ask about this question, the answer — the expected and self-evident one — will be: "just because!" What has, in effect, happened here is that, in the final accounting, in order to explain even the purposive reason, I must use causal language and explanation, dealing with the foundational, inner motive force, which has no reason derived from without.[12]

It follows that the purposive language for explaining will stands, in its entirety, upon the causal language; causality remains at the foundation of the explanation, and this because it is what truly describes what occurs within a person, and what brings him to action. A person is driven from within, from some totality of wills and tendencies, of motives and drives. These inner forces push him to perform deeds and to achieve certain results, but at times, in order to arrive at these deeds and results in reality, he must first perform intermediate deeds, which lead, in their results, to the sought-after matter itself.

## F.

In my view, the linguistic difference between "values" and "ideals" rests mainly on this axis. Education toward ideals is education that makes use of various sketches of a repaired reality, of certain ways through which we wish to influence reality and improve it, and focuses on these. An idealistic person is a person who tries very hard — through study and thought — to build for himself an orderly system of ideals, that is, of supreme goals and destinations on the one hand, and of general and particular ways of action on the other. Ideology is essential for him, it is his conscience and his life's teaching, without which he is unable to actualize his whole enthusiastic and deep will for a better world, for a more complete and higher reality.

The ideal of the youth movement itself is a good example to illustrate the matter. The movement's counselees are educated to believe that the existence of the movement, its success and its elevation, carry very great importance, and that it is an effective and good way to act, and to influence social, educational and political reality through it. Trust in the movement becomes a value in its own right, and the educational message is that there is an essential advantage (I would almost say: a moral advantage) in this belief in the movement's way of action, for without it, how would we be active, how would we actualize our good will, how would we have influence, how would we do something meaningful?

The same holds for the more "abstract" ideals, which deal not only with the "how" of positive activity but also with the "toward where." Let us take the kibbutz as an example. The kibbutz ideal was built and formulated through a shared clarification among thinkers and pioneers, each with the other, and all together tried to determine the question — what does the ideal communal-settlement way of existence look like, one that implements the full range of values we wish to actualize in our way of life? Even if there were many differences of opinion on the various, countless details making up the character of the kibbutz and its life, in the end some general ethos of the kibbutz was formed, including foundational features of cooperation, equality, productivity and the like. Indeed, the socialist-collective ideal does not deal with the question of how to have influence and how to bring about the repaired reality, but with the foundational aspiration, the vision, the dream. But this ideal, too, is concerned with the actual world, and what truly troubles it is how to actualize the group members' rootedness moral wills — their values — within the vessel of reality in an optimal way.

A value is a general name for all the "high" motives within a person, all the wills that exceed the natural, bodily and egoistic will-drive. The values a person holds constitute the foundational basis, the skeleton and the essence of his spiritual and moral being. Within every person there exists a kind of "list" of values, which, together with the relationship among them — along with the way he sees reality — will make up the whole of his ideological worldview, in all its layers. Kindness, human dignity, modesty, truth, equality, gratitude, friendship, justice, sincerity, freedom, sensitivity to nature, mercy — all these are examples of values that generate and constitute the doing, the activism, the movements and

the ideologies that come to repair matters in the world. Every deed a person does for the sake of some general result, for a purpose that does not touch on private self-interest, is driven, within the person, by force of the values he holds.

Against idealistic education I set value-based education.[13] Value-based education focuses on the inner-psychic domain and on the question of what I truly want, what stands at the foundation of my system of motivation. It is work of the heart, the refinement of character, a self-clarification of what is fitting to drive me to action, what is good and what is fitting to seek and to do. The educator does not focus his power of persuasion and influence on ideological questions, since the foundation is, first of all, the very sense of the worth of values, the very commitment to values. What the educator seeks to shape in the student is focused on his principled wills, on what he wants and how much he truly wants it; an educator will feel he has succeeded when he sees that what occupies his student are important things, that this is what he cares about, this is what troubles and excites him, this is what overrides, within him, lower considerations — even if the counselee takes the values in which he was educated and actualizes them in a way different from, and opposed to, the educator's own way, and even if he does not find a successful way to actualize them in practice. The educator does indeed lay out before the student a complete and orderly worldview of ideals and of correct deeds, but the essential thing, the heart, is not found there, but in the values that constitute that conception.

This shift of focus, from ideals to values, is called for not only from the side of "the illumination of the times," from the side of the general cultural mindset of our day, but is also correct in its own right[14]. The main fervor, enthusiasm, certainty and inner orientation ought to be directed toward values, and this not only because they are the root of all idealism and of positive activism, but also because it is only in them that one can truly hold that same unshakable certainty. The bond between a person and a value is unmediated, incapable of being justified or explained, and also incapable of being refuted — there is no further "why" that can apply to it. It is a direct intuition, an axiom[15], the cornerstone from which the whole ethical world is subsequently built[16]. Certainty whose object is some factual matter, a practical-actual matter, like a political program or a social movement, will always be relative and non-total, and this is so as a matter of truth. Group-belonging does indeed sometimes blur authentic personal thought, and drags a person toward opinions and deeds that are not necessarily an accurate reflection of his refined, true, authentic, sincere inner idea. The optimistic outlook is indeed a more pleasant and good mindset to live by, but there are also states of mind in which optimism is not possible or does not apply, and it has an unstable element within it owing to the fact that it is not necessary from the side of reality. In utopianism there is indeed some disconnection from the simple, objective reality that imposes itself on a person against his will, even if he believes otherwise.

**G.**

Since the value-based language, as against the idealistic one, deals more with inner-psychic content and less with realia and action, it also constitutes a great educational risk. A value does indeed demand unconditional commitment, but since the practical translation of a value is always shrouded in fog, always standing in tension against other values, needs and wills — the escape from total devotion to it is easy, and, in fact, it is far from certain that we will attain that same devotion to a goal, that same assertiveness, that same activist-idealistic fervor. The moment the path of actualization remains undefined, and the moment it remains in the personal, private domain, in the domain of individual self-thought, it does not have that same power, that same flight, that enables the establishment of some real initiative, the building of undertakings and the bringing about of change. Values often remain "potential"; they do indeed obligate me in a situation in which I encounter them in a clear and unambiguous way, but they do not run me forward to seek them out and pursue them, they do not push me with force to find the optimal way to actualize them positively in reality. This is precisely the reason the idealistic educational approach continues to hold on to its language, since it knows, from the reality around it, that one who abandons the idealistic language and mindset, in the end, also abandons the doing, the enthusiasm, the devotion and the readiness to bear the burden for the sake of his values and ideals.

The truly great challenge of the shift to a "value-based" language is the ability to establish vigorous activism, and I believe this is possible. It is possible when, beyond a deep internalization of values, we also instill the value of responsibility and the value of activism as values in themselves; and this in two senses.

First, every person of spiritual and moral sensitivity feels that his striving toward the good, his striving to be good and to do good, is measured by the level of actualization of his good wills. The sincere value-oriented person asks himself how much the values he holds burn in his very bones, how much he truly longs to actualize them. For with a sufficiently strong longing for something, a person is willing to devote himself, to labor and to toil even for the mere chance, a person is willing to do what is in his power to do even in a state of uncertainty as to whether it will indeed succeed and bring about what he seeks. The value of activism and actualization is, in fact, not a separate value; it is a derivative of the depth and quality of the commitment to values, for within this commitment there is a demand not only for their actualization in a moment of decision, but also in the mundane, day to day; actualization is a function of the very readiness to make an effort to actualize the value, which is the clearest expression of the weight of the value within a person's psychic being.

Second, the value of actualization and activism can be understood from a different direction, namely, from the side of the character of man. It is indeed true that idealistic doing comes in order to achieve these or those lofty goals, but beyond these primary purposes, there is intrinsic value in the very fact that a person is an active person, in the fact that he is a caring, alert person, involved in reality. One who seeks to act only out of certainty, or only out of a broad-reaching, highly influential result, will, in the end, reach a dead end, and will thus find himself living a narrow, egoistic, constricted life. A person is a whole person only if he adopts for himself the trait of caring, involvement, responsibility and initiative; these traits

attest to his quality, to the power of his good will. And this, in itself, constitutes a reason to seek the way and to look for means — more successful or less successful — to actualize values in reality, to advance the good in the world in practice.

A person who understands that activism itself is a value, a person who seeks ways to do good, will know how to act even along uncertain paths, since there is no other choice — it is better for him to try and fail than not to try, and it is better for him to labor and succeed at some small thing than to despair. He is careful not to sink into laziness and inaction, not only out of the work of character, but because this is not the correct way to live; the correct way is a constant weighing of chance and risk, of effort and price against possible benefit, but with a constant will and orientation toward doing, toward what can and should, nonetheless, be done.

It is worth stressing that there are still many differences between the activist "value-oriented person" and the idealist. The value-oriented person does indeed try to devote his powers to repair and to actualization, but, on the other hand, he does not force himself to hold specifically certain beliefs or to see reality in a certain way. He grants himself the legitimacy to abandon some undertaking, or to reduce the strength and resources he invests in some matter, if he is not certain of its effectiveness and its benefit. On the one hand, a distorted reality will indeed pain his heart greatly, and will lead him to seek a way and to be part of the repair of the situation, but, on the other hand, it will not scramble his entire world and will not remove him from a balanced perspective regarding his personal duty toward this situation and his level of responsibility for the matter. He will not despair even when it seems there is no real way to reach the supreme goals, the wonderful dreams and the lofty visions, since he knows the healthy balance of "it is not upon you to finish the work, but neither are you free to desist from it." He knows how to continue working even when his spirit is fallen and pessimism clothes him, since his deeds come from a modest, intimate, rooted commitment, from which there is no escaping. He copes with doubts, since his basic orientation is commitment to the good, to empathy, to walking in the ways of God, even if the deeds he does may, in retrospect, turn out to have been unnecessary, "a waste of time." He looks at things from the perspective of his own existence, and therefore his nullity and his limited ability to influence on a large, macro scale does not incapacitate him, but rather leaves him to direct the proper and correct relation between the cultivation and elevation of his private spiritual world and his bond to the collective.

The value-oriented activist does not surrender to skepticism, not because there is no truth in it at all, and not because he denies the rational sides with which he identifies within it, but because this very surrender is itself illegitimate from a value standpoint; he teaches himself that although it is not fully clear to him what the correct way is, and how and what would be best to do, it is clear to him that it is highly negative to sink into apathy, self-centeredness and "keeping a low profile" out of that same doubt. The value-oriented person understands that commitment to abstract moral values is not enough, and that one must also make the effort to establish "ideals" — visions, directions, destinations, agendas, modes of action, movements, projects, associations, and so on — whose concern is to channel

practical life toward the supreme purposes. He knows that without these there is no way to found a way of life on doing and repair, and therefore he takes part in their clarification and their adoption; except that, at the same time, he always remembers their relative, instrumental, inherently uncertain role. He does not stake everything on a single ideal whose chances and benefit are entirely unclear, but neither does he withdraw from the whole game into self-centered withdrawal. The value-oriented person places himself within purpose-oriented groups, even though this creates tension with the individual character of his spiritual, intellectual and moral world, since he is aware that this is the best way to act and to bring change; yet, at the same time, he preserves for himself freedom of thought and spiritual independence, and leaves a gap and a partition between his social-group self and his inwardness. The value-oriented person allows himself to be driven by a great spirit of enthusiastic vision and of deep longing for a repaired and complete reality, but, nonetheless, he does not act out of pretension, nor out of an attempt to believe that all this will indeed happen as a result of his deeds, "and if not tomorrow, then the day after."

In short, one could say that the value-oriented person is driven by the force of a constant logic of examining alternatives. On the one hand, he is careful not to become addicted to a single ideal or idea, when there may be others more important, and he is willing, when necessary, to open himself to thought and skepticism regarding the rightness of the path and the effectiveness of the means. But, on the other hand, in every situation in which he leans toward doubt and inaction, every time he abandons a certain ideal, he asks himself what the alternative is; whether there is indeed something better — by the most intuitive and simple definition of "better" — to do with his time and his strength.

## **H.**

As people of faith, above all those values in which we believe stands one single source of authority, namely, the will of God. For the religious person, the will of God is the obligating force of all values and of all fitting deeds, and there is no other source outside its domain — "you shall have no other gods before Me." Negation and affirmation, good and evil, the beautiful and the repugnant, are measured and defined according to the supreme, all-encompassing concept of the will of God, according to the question "what does the LORD your God ask of you." [17]

Religious doing, in its natural form, is closer to activity out of values than to activity out of ideals, since the person's basic orientation in this doing cannot be found in some specific real-world result. The religious command is, at its root, obscure; its reason and its purpose are essentially hidden from us. Even if we try, with our human reason, to trace the reasons for the commandments, the purpose of things, the difficult root of religiosity lies in "we will do and we will hear," in the intention to do the will of God and the word of God without any external justification, without explanation, but only because God so commanded. In this, religiosity is oriented from a motive and not from a purpose. [18]

The fact that, for the religious activist, God is the "first mover" of all his deeds, of all his values and of his entire worldview, supplies him with even stronger answers to the

questions that undermine his idealism. The religious activist's foundational stance is before God; his pursuit of the repair of reality and his responsibility for what occurs in the world flow from his intimate commitment to God, and to God alone. His entire world can be summed up in his covenant with God, in the service of God and the doing of His will. Except that God Himself, immediately after the person's total devotion to Him, and to Him alone, turns the person's gaze outward, beyond the circle of the intimate covenant between him and his Creator, demands of him to bring to Him not only himself alone but the entire world God created, all His children, and bequeaths to him the mission of repairing the world under the kingdom of the Almighty.

The person who turns to the world out of the pursuit of the service of God turns to it differently.

First, he has the ability to sever the questions and doubts that exist regarding his path in repairing the world from the motivation, the inner fuel that drives him to engage in this with all his energy and enthusiasm. Of course, he must still give an account of the question "what is the will of God regarding the repair of the world," since we have no clear way of knowing what is correct and good, what is effective and beneficial. However, in the background of all this wondering and clarifying shines the recognition that "the Merciful One desires the heart," that "the LORD is near to all who call upon Him," and that "He keeps the feet of His pious ones"; against the foundational skepticism regarding the question of what God wants, one can sharply feel the faith that God wants us to labor for the good, to be caring, to remove the foreskin of the heart and to make our efforts to add light, good, wisdom, love and holiness to the world. The same applies to general optimism — constructive activity is undertaken not necessarily out of a deep faith in the distant, utopian implications of the deed, but simply because God commanded that we conduct ourselves as though our deeds have meaning. A person need not stand before pessimistic forces that flood him and fight them — he flees from them into the bosom of God, and draws from the love of God the energy to act even against the odds, idealistic activity as the fulfillment of a religious command, as the giving of an offering, as an appeasement and a bringing of satisfaction before God.

Second, the fact remains that responsibility toward the world is only one of the religious duties placed on a person's shoulders. Because of this, altruism does not take over the whole of his world, does not conquer concern for his own narrow personal environment and his personal spiritual demand, but stands, in itself, as an important and central part — of a person's purpose in the world.

Third, the meaning and criticality of small things is intensified. It is not only that the individual person receives added importance through the religious lens — the private, small deed, too, is magnified through this lens. The idealistic view of reality accustoms us to attribute value only to great things, only to general-public matters, matters that changed something real in collective reality. From this viewpoint, even with a sharpened sense of personal responsibility for choice and decision, it is hard not to arrive at a certain despair, at a feeling of "what profit has man of all his labor which he labors under the sun," "what am I,



what is my life," what can I really change? When deeds are measured by the external, real-general view, it is hard to grant a small deed — negative or positive — truly critical meaning. But if the measure, the director, the judge, is, at bottom, God alone — then our entire judgment of things changes. A small kindness I did for an elderly woman on the street, some true insight I taught my counselees, a quarrel between friends that I helped resolve, the warm countenance I showed another — all of it takes on heroic, absolute, infinite meaning. The same holds, in general, for my life, or for my family unit — they are not measured only by their statistical weight or their influence on the life of the nation, but their character is important and critical in itself, in its singularity. God turns to me in my individuality and asks for my deeds, and I respond to Him.

Beyond all this, a person's experience of life is not that of one bearing a burden, driven and demanded by some foreign psychic source contrary to his being. The experience is one of intimate bond, of willing, of service, of love and devotion. God — the source of the demand, the source of the commitment, the source of the values — stands with us in a relation of "face to face," and this is the whole of man.

## I.

Let me summarize the main points of what I have said.

In this essay I dealt with the existing phenomenon of the abandonment, by graduates of idealistic education, of the values of "idealism." I characterized the idealistic mindset by five characteristics, which constitute weighty components of the idealistic worldview and way of life: the strong grip on certainty, the standing of the group, trust in the influential power of the individual, optimism and utopianism. I described how all these components are undergoing a trend of weakening in the culture of our time, in which postmodern winds blow that undermine ethoses that were central in the modern era. Beyond the sociological description, analyzing from without, I also expressed the identification I feel — and, I believe, that many of us feel — with the echoes of this critique, and our internalization of the fundamental skepticism regarding all the non-necessary claims about reality. Except that, alongside the internalization of the critique of the foundations of the idealistic-modernist mindset, there is also within it an undeniable blessing, namely, the ability to establish a psychic status of devotion and activist diligence, of active fervor and of vigorous, high-flying value-based actualization. In the final reckoning, we owe a great deal to those people who devoted themselves to idealistic actualization, each in his own domain, most of whom advanced and repaired (and still advance and repair) to one degree or another the social, environmental and political reality in which we live.

The central question for which I sought an answer is, therefore, how one can establish constructive activism when we no longer hold those same dogmas and foundational beliefs, how one can engage in intensive actualization from our present psychic-cultural starting point. To this end I created a conceptual distinction between "values" and "ideals," at the root of which lies the difference between two ways of explaining human will — causal explanation and purposive (teleological) explanation. The "ideal" is an expression of an

initiative, of some particular way of action or of some particular vision, by means of which, or toward which, we seek to direct and elevate reality. The "value," by contrast, is the psychic motive, the foundational moral-spiritual will-force that drives toward the various positive trends. Out of this distinction, two different principled-educational languages are also created — an "ideological" language and a "value-based" language — which differ from one another regarding which component is emphasized on the will-deed axis, or "value"—"ideal."

The value-based approach places less emphasis on agreement about the correct deed, or on a description of the desired reality down to its details, and deals more with the very positive will, with the very commitment to values such as honesty, kindness and solidarity. Its education is focused on a person's inner decision to be driven by high, moral wills and by commitment to them. The ability of the value-based language to establish activism full of fervor depends not only on a deep internalization of the values a person believes in, but also on the internalization of the value of activism as a value in its own right, both from the side of the importance of bringing principled values down into deeds, and from the side of the character of the whole person as one who struggles with evil and copes with, and shapes, the reality around him. By means of this language, a person succeeds in finding the balance between not placing excessive trust in all sorts of dogmas and specific deeds that do not sincerely justify total certainty, and caution against sinking into comfortable self-centeredness and laziness disguised in a skeptical cloak. Upon the value-based language, the faith-based language is built, which draws its entire motivation from a single source called the will of God. The believing person turns to the world out of his turning to God and his petition to Him, and thereby finds himself both more resistant to the will-incapacitating skepticism, and more balanced regarding the egocentric-altruistic dilemma, and more sensitive to the criticality of every deed and moment. And above all, he acts in the difficult, flawed and demanding world of doing not merely out of a sense of burden, but out of an experience of love, devotion and satisfaction — "for God has already accepted your deeds with favor."

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## Notes

1. I exclude the various scouting movements, which were created for a somewhat different purpose, although also out of a tendency toward social change, and there is no room here for that discussion.
2. I write about Bnei Akiva out of convenience, since that is where I grew up, but the matters apply, more or less equally, to religious youth movements in general. The same holds throughout the rest of the essay.
3. Joel 3:5. See also Ein Ayah, Berakhot 2, chapter 9, verse 342 — a passage I encountered many times in the course of my Bnei-Akiva-ist education.
4. Whose source, as far as I know, is a Bnei Akiva educational guidance booklet.
5. That is, grades 9–12.

6. See the entry "sixism" or "chill-mode-ism" [terms of derision, in Israeli youth-movement slang, for a lazy, indifferent, unideological attitude].

7. In order to better understand the characteristics I will note, let me remark that the idealism of which I speak corresponds, in its period and its concern, to "modernism," which is my own term for the era of the great ideologies (the time of the formation of the youth movements) — from the 19th century to the mid-20th century. I define modernism largely by contrast with postmodernism, but it has a prior essence in its own right, out of those same cultures, philosophies and ideologies created during that period.

8. One could say that the first two questions are necessary preliminary questions for the great central question — what should be done?

9. See note 7.

10. Historically, this is not at all self-evident. The classical, or traditional, religious conception found it difficult to contain many of the modern components that seem to us today self-evident and understood as part of the religious spirit, such as universalism (altruism), activism, trust in human potential and in the ability to actualize it, and more. The spiritual teaching of Rav Kook, for example, which arose out of a deep, piercing and complex struggle, seems to us already trivial from a religious standpoint, whereas at the time of its creation (and against the background against which it appeared) it was, in this respect, an innovation and a revolution.

11. I wrote at length and in detail about the two systems for explaining human will in my essay "Le-Shem Shamayim," which appeared in Petichta 14, published by Yeshivat Hesder Petach Tikva, chapters 2–6. Whoever wishes to understand more deeply the difference between the systems, the foundational ontological priority of the causal system, the reason for the formation of the teleological system, and further discussion of the matter of free choice in light of the causal-mechanical description of the will, should look there.

12. It should be noted that the "stuckness" and the logical flaw do not lie in the fact that I arrived at the answer "just because"; this will always happen when we advance through a chain of questions of "why" upon "why." Rather, the causal description of the will is more direct, and even if it contains intermediate stages (that is: answers to the question "why," which are themselves the reason for the previous answer), it remains "within its own domain," within the language of causal explanation. Whereas what happened in the purposive language is that, when we "pressed" and continued to ask why regarding the first answers, we ultimately arrived at a "reversal" of language, and received a causal answer ("because") to a purposive question ("for what purpose").

13. I set them against one another in a polarized and contrasting way only for the sake of a sharp illustration and clarification of their own self-definitions. In reality, this is mainly a matter of a distinction of emphasis, of granting greater decisive educational weight to one of the two sides on the axis of value–deed, or will–actualization.

14. In general, when we see a cultural-spiritual movement rising up against some matter, or against a previous cultural-spiritual movement, it is reasonable to say that there is some good and truth in their claims, and it is better to relate to the uprising as something substantial, which must be clarified and which can itself clarify things, rather than to ignore it and tighten our grip on the conception we already hold.

15. An axiom is a foundational assumption on the plane of the recognition of being, "what exists?" — epistemology. A value, by contrast, is the parallel of the axiom on the plane of the recognition of the good, "what is fitting?" — ethics. For sharpened definitions and elaboration, see the book by Rav Michael Avraham, Enosh Ke-Chatzir.

16. Under the term "ethics" I include also all values whose source is religious, since, for this purpose, they belong to the same plane — the plane of fitting deeds.

**17. "And now, Israel, what does the LORD your God ask of you, but to fear the LORD your God, to walk in all His ways, and to love Him, and to serve the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul, to keep the commandments of the LORD, and His statutes, which I command you this day for your good" (Deut. 10:12-13).**

**18. On this, see at length in my essay "Le-Shem Shamayim," mentioned above (note 11).**